

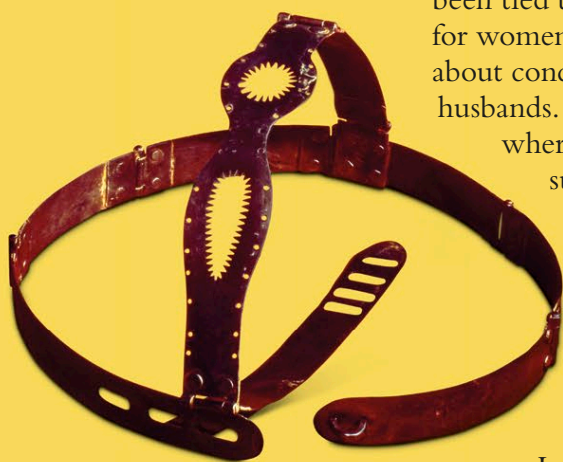
“Come, my **beloved**, let us go **forth** into the **field** ... Let us **get up early** to the **vineyards** ... there will I **give thee my loves**.”

THE BIBLE, SONG OF SONGS 7:12

## EXPERIENCES OF SEXUALITY

# Sex and sexuality

In many societies, female sexuality was—and still is—a taboo subject. A woman’s virginity was prized above all else, and her sexual behavior was a subject of intense scrutiny, while double standards meant that men enjoyed far greater freedoms.



### ▲ Locked down

Chastity belts were iron locking devices supposedly worn by medieval women to prevent them from intercourse. Some historians now consider their widespread use a 19th-century myth.

**THROUGH THE AGES**, a woman’s worth has been tied to her virginity. Sexual intercourse, for women, was not about pleasure, but rather about conceiving children and pleasing their husbands. Historically, and today in societies where female sexuality remains suppressed, women have been punished for being promiscuous, or for simply being perceived to have committed a sin, such as having sex outside of marriage. Women’s partners, however, were likely to receive little or no censure for such actions.

In 1900 BCE, women’s sexual urges were characterized as a medical condition. The ancient Greek philosopher Plato described such urges as a “wandering womb,” which likely led to the term “hysteria” (“womb disease”)—a diagnosis that became common 4,000 years later, during the Victorian era.

The medicalization of women’s sexuality led to extreme methods of treatment. Mentions of chastity belts dating to the 6th century CE in Europe suggest that some societies went to great physical lengths to prevent women from giving in to sexual temptation—although evidence suggests that such devices were mainly used to protect women from rape by invaders during times of war. During the Victorian era, “hysterical” women were placed in mental asylums, where a common treatment was to induce orgasms or “hysterical paroxysms.” Today, the practice of female genital cutting in parts of Africa, Asia, and the Middle East also discourages women from sex by making the act a painful prospect.

While women were not expected to have strong sexual urges, they were expected to have enough knowledge and enjoyment of the act to please their husbands. According to legend, Helen of Troy’s maid Astyanassa wrote the first book on sexual positions, suggesting

“[She] **preferred** her **pleasure** to **all the honor** in the **world** ... and **carried** her **head high**.”

MARGUERITE OF NAVARRE,  
1558